

Unlettered Regenerative Floor

The articulatory-auditory floor beneath descent and an infra-Nostratic account of convergence across Semitic and Indo-European languages · Mohammad F. Islam, PhD

Beneath every reconstructible language family there is no older language to reconstruct. There is a floor that is never inherited: the finite lattice of stable vocal-tract closures, the corners of the vowel space, and the category boundaries the ear imposes, rebuilt in every infant. Unrelated families converge on the same sound-meaning pairings because they share the generator, not an ancestor; the comparative method cannot reach it because a regenerated generator leaves no correspondence to read; every phonetic script records a perceptual cut the ear had already made, segmental awareness left open; and the three physical generators of speech vary independently across the world's inventories, almost perfectly so once descent is projected out.

WHAT THE PAPER CLAIMS, IN SIX LINES

- 1. A generator beneath descent, regenerated per infant; nursery immunity to sound law is its test (F1, stated as a corpus study, unrun).
- 2. The cross-family residue survives projection of descent, borrowing, and script, and its only measured correlate is the shared tract and ear.
- 3. Script is downstream of the perceptual cut; segmental awareness is left open, with the literacy literature on its side.

- 4. Constriction, resonance, and phonation inventories are independent across 3,020 inventories (Gram volume 0.92) and within families once means are removed (0.99); descent couples, regeneration decouples. Executed on PHOIBLE and Glottolog.
- 5. The three-consonant Semitic root is a code of least sufficient length, not a signature of the floor: closed form, 1,651 Quranic roots measured, 2.05 bits of freedom in the third slot, the homorganic constraint replicated.
- 6. The speech loop is a damped self-witnessing recurrence with a 200 ms carrier found in three literatures; against the generative program the floor supersedes nothing at syntax and contradicts one thesis on measured ground: the externalization substrate it calls ancillary is where the exceptionless universals live.

HOW THE PAPER STANDS TO EACH PRIOR POSITION

PRIOR POSITION	WHAT IT HOLDS	WHAT THIS PAPER DOES WITH IT	RELATION	EVIDENCE
Tabula rasa; behaviourist learning (Locke; Skinner 1957)	Language is learned onto a blank surface.	The surface has a grain. The lattice is innate because it is anatomy; the inventory is learned because it is pruned into that lattice (perceptual narrowing at 6 to 12 months). Neither module nor slate.	Replacing	Cited: Werker and Tees 1984; Kuhl 1992; Eimas 1971; Kuhl and Miller 1975
Universal Grammar; narrow faculty as recursion (Chomsky 1965; Hauser, Chomsky and Fitch 2002; Berwick and Chomsky 2016)	An innate syntactic computation; externalization ancillary and the locus of mere variation.	Says nothing about syntax and supersedes nothing there. Fills the sensory-motor interface the program hands to biology. Contradicts ancillarity: the only exceptionless universals in the data, three place classes at 100 per cent, vowel corners at 76 to 81, three independent generators, live in externalization; the syntactic universals are carried by argument.	Additive at the interface; contradicting on ancillarity	Executed: PHOIBLE, 3,020 inventories
Substance-free phonology; innate universal features (Chomsky and Halle 1968; Hale and Reiss 2000)	Distinctive features are formal primitives, stipulated.	Derives the features from tube and ear (quantal plateaus, categorical boundaries) and supplies counts a substance-free account must stipulate.	Contradicting	Executed counts; Stevens 1972, 1989 cited
Arbitrariness of the sign (Saussure 1916)	The sign is arbitrary at its foundation.	Iconicity is the seed and arbitrariness the accretion; as a foundation the postulate is retired, as a description of the bulk of any vocabulary it is kept.	Contradicting as foundation; retaining as description	Blasi et al. 2016 read; projection argument
Iconicity program (Blasi et al. 2016; Dingemanse et al. 2015; Perniss and Vigliocco 2014)	Non-arbitrariness is pervasive; its cause is left as the human condition.	Names the cause as a generator, bounds it by four faces, types it infra-Nostratic, forces it by a three-projection argument, and requires a boundary failure before any iconicity claim counts.	Subsuming	Read: Blasi 2016; Ćwiek 2022; Styles and Gawne 2017 for the boundary
Nostratic and its critics (Illich-Svitych; Bomhard; Ringe 1995; Campbell)	Cross-family resemblance is descent, or it is chance.	A third option: regeneration. The descent question is left exactly where it stands; the resemblances no longer need it.	Subsuming the dilemma	Argued; executed independence supports the third option
Comparative-method ceiling (Nichols 1992; Ringe 1995)	Correspondence signal is lost beyond eight to ten millennia.	Agrees, and explains why the regularities survive it: a regenerated generator leaves no correspondence to read.	Corroborating with a mechanism	Argued

Nursery words (Jakobson 1960; Murdock 1959)	mama and papa are regenerated from infant articulation.	Generalized to the whole floor; stated as a corpus test across families with established sound laws, statistic and firing condition fixed.	Additive	Test stated, unrun
Design features (Hockett 1960)	Vocal-auditory channel, interchangeability, total feedback, listed.	Gives each its physics: source-filter and cochlea as Fourier duals, the loop's gain and phase, same-kind mimicry as the selection story.	Subsuming	Fant 1960; Békésy 1960; Guenther 2006 cited
Quantal theory; dispersion; self-organizing inventories (Stevens; Liljencrants and Lindblom 1972; de Boer 2000; Oudeyer 2006)	Inventory shape follows from tract and ear.	Taken as the production face; adds the independence of the three generators across the world and its sharpening under the descent projection.	Additive on data	Executed: 0.921, 0.911, 0.993
Speech is special against auditory-general perception (Liberman; Kuhl and Miller 1975)	Boundaries are motor, or they are auditory.	Both, at different rungs: the boundary is auditory-mechanical (chinchilla, one-month infant); the loop is motor-coupled (dorsal stream, mirror activation).	Reconciling	Cited
Literacy makes the phoneme (Olson 1994; Faber 1992; Morais et al. 1979; Ziegler and Goswami 2005)	Segment awareness derives from alphabetic literacy.	Accepted. The script-downstream law is scoped to the perceptual cut; acrophony is re-read as the earliest recorded act of segmentation; the India question (segmental phonology under a non-alphabetic script) is named as the test.	Corroborating and scoping	Cited; open
Phonetization of writing (Gelb 1963)	Logogram to syllabary to alphabet.	Every phonetization event, rebus, acrophony, the Greek guttural-to-vowel transfer, Linear B's lossiness, is a receipt of an ear-cut; script is downstream by construction.	Reframing	Documentary
Orality and scripture (Ong 1982; Havelock; Graham 1987)	Scripture is recited and heard before it is read.	A dated roster of scripts and scriptures placing the mouth before the pen, the chant row, the scripture names by the ear.	Corroborating	Documentary
Semitic root theories (Hurwitz 1913; McCarthy 1981; Bohas and Dat 2007; Ibn Jinni)	Three radicals as structure, tiers, or meaning-bearing matrices.	The root is a code of least sufficient length under a combinatorial constraint, with a closed form; on 1,651 Quranic roots, 46 per cent are two closures in the mouth, the third slot carries 2.05 bits, and the radicals are positions, not dimensions.	Correcting; additive on data	Executed on the Quranic corpus
Root constraints (Greenberg 1950; Frisch, Pierrehumbert and Broe 2004)	Homorganic adjacency is avoided.	Replicated on the Quranic set: 0.68 of independence, and the asymmetry exact, zero identical pairs at the first joint against 154 at the second.	Corroborating	Executed
Articulatory phonology; frame-content (Browman and Goldstein 1992; MacNeilage 1998)	The gesture is the primitive; the syllable is a jaw cycle.	The mouth cuts; the syllable is the loop's carrier at about 200 ms.	Kin	Cited
Control-loop and predictive accounts (Guenther 2006; Houde 2002; Friston 2010)	Speech is a feedback-controlled, prediction-driven loop.	The loop read as a damped self-witnessing recurrence at two grains, milliseconds within a speaker and seconds between speakers, its 200 ms period found in the syllable, delayed feedback, and turn-taking.	Subsuming; additive exhibit	Cited; the convergence an exhibit, not a claim
Phonological loop as the origin of the language areas (Aboitiz and García 1997; Aboitiz 2012)	Auditory-vocal working memory is the evolutionary core.	Held as the one bridge from the floor toward syntax, open; reached independently by the author from sensory constraints in 2014, the two roads converging.	Kin; open	Cited
Gesture-first against vocal-first origins (Corballis; Arbib; Darwin 1871; Mithen 2005)	Which channel came first.	A channel is a floor wherever its receiving organ has an emitting twin; the vocal channel wins for same-kind mimicry at distance, and signed languages are predicted to be iconic, which they are.	Scoping	Cited
Language is not for communication (Chomsky)	Communication is a by-product.	Broadcast transmission, interchangeability, and total feedback are a communication design; the floor sides with the design.	Competing	Argued on Hockett's features, not executed
Nativism against empiricism (Spelke; the modularity debate)	Innate modules, or none.	At the phonic register a third position: innate lattice, learned inventory.	Third position	Argued on executed counts

Relation words, used as defined. **Additive:** supplies a result or a test the position lacked and leaves it standing. **Replacing:** retires a metaphor or framing and puts a measured object in its place. **Superseding:** used nowhere; the paper supersedes no theory, and says so. **Competing:** a different position on the same question, argued and not executed. **Subsuming:** the prior claim becomes a case or a consequence of the floor. **Corroborating:** independent agreement, which confers no warrant and is counted as such. **Contradicting:** a named thesis is denied on executed data, never on argument alone; the paper carries three, and this table carries the same three. **Scoping:** the prior claim is kept inside a stated boundary.

What this paper does not do. It does not validate or refute any macro-family. It does not make iconicity the ceiling of the lexicon. It admits no letter shape as evidence. It identifies no three with any other three. It supersedes no theory of the clause. **What it asks of this room.** Families with established sound laws for the nursery-immunity test; a cortical dataset on which the neural rungs can be executed rather than cited; and anyone who can say whether ancient India practised segmental phonology under a non-alphabetic script.

Full paper: Unlettered Regenerative Floor, 20 pp., three forced falsification criteria, two of them run, four executed batteries with data digests, 109 references, closing on the table above. Method disclosed in the paper's appendix; the method adds the cited results no warrant. Correspondence: islaamm@alumni.iu.edu.